

Title DE Amplification of Russian Media Sphere by @PolitRealist

05/03/2024

Summary

- Between 15th and the 22nd of February, an account was flagged for facilitating sanctioned Russian-state affiliated media. The account interact in large with pro-Russian X accounts, as well as localising disinformative content from the Russian media sphere by translating Russian content into German.
- Narratives pushed by the account have aligned with the pro-Kremlin disinformation, specifically criticism of the German government, support for the AfD, and the mirroring of Russian views regarding Ukraine and Zelensky.
- The impact includes the continued spread of content and narratives from sanctioned media sources.
- The objective of the threat actor is to facilitate state propaganda by amplifying and localising sanctioned media and having ties to known pro-Russian disinformation spreaders on X.
- Recommended course of action is to limit the accessibility of their content within Germany.

Incident

On February 21st, @PolitRealist posted a tweet (1) claiming that Zelensky has a 15.9% approval rating. These statistics have been traced to originate from Izvestia (2), a state affiliated media outlet. The outlet's controlling share is currently owned by Gazprom (3), a sanctioned entity. The information is also disinformative, as per an article published by Reuters on the same date as the tweet (4), the approval ratings are currently at 63%.

On February 22nd, @PolitRealist posted a tweet (5) in German, where the author quotes an authentic statement from the German Foreign Minister. However, the post frames the statement to express that Europe is against resolution of the war in Ukraine. The position presented by the tweet is found to be sourced from an article posted by Gazeta.ru (6), which is a Russian state-affiliated media owned by the sanctioned entity Gazprom. In both cases, the account has localised and amplified content published by state-owned sanctioned media outlets.

The account's activity in the days leading up to the German elections have continued to center around German officials, German elections and the war in Ukraine, as @PolitRealist's activity grew from 60 average tweets a day to 97. The account is closely associated with pro-Russian Telegrams and X accounts, who also amplify sanctioned media and pro-Kremlin disinformation (7). The majority of the mentioned accounts with most recorded interactions are infamous for systematic spread of pro-Russian disinformation, such as [Sprinter](#) (an account connected to a Belarusian state operative), [Olga Bazova](#) and [DD geopolitics](#) (a prominent pro-Kremlin social media account implicated in the recent leak of classified documents on the Ukraine war (8)). Between February 13th and 21st, @PolitRealist has disseminated 14 pieces of content linked to sanctioned media sources or has amplified pro-Russian disinformation concerning the German elections.

The account is additionally known to amplify AI generated or altered pro-Kremlin content. On February 21st, @PolitRealist posted the following tweet (9), localising the anti-Ukrainian disinformation piece by translating it into German. The initial content has been posted by a Telegram channel Novyny Pravdy (10), which is known for having a strong anti-Ukraine, pro-Russia sentiments and posting cases of AI-altered disinformation (11).

Narrative

Meta narrative: Traditional pro-Russian narratives.

Sub-narratives: Anti-Ukraine sentiment; criticism of the ruling parties in Germany.

Impact

The reach has been moderate. The tweets that amplified sanctioned media or disinformative content from the Russian media-sphere reached 243010 views, 2068 retweets, 6652 likes, 505 favourites, and 1675 comments. The practical impact is that sanctioned Russian media content is being translated and amplified within the German social media sphere, influencing perceptions of the German elections and promoting the Russian state media's perspective on the electoral process.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective: [T0002: Facilitate State Propagand](#) spreading content from sanctioned Russian state affiliated media.

[T0060: Continue to Amplify](#), due to amplification of accounts and stories sourced from pro-Russian telegram and x accounts.

[T0101: Create Localised Content](#), due to translation of Russian propagandist content into German.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Recommendations: limit the reach of the account on x.com, specifically in Germany;

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	Logo
N/A	Amplification of Russian media sphere	Link , Link 2 , Link 3	Debunk	X.com, Telegram	